

The Lamb and The Tyger

- *William Blake*



William Blake was born in London and was educated at Henry Pars Drawing School before becoming an apprentice to the engraver, James Basire (1772-79). By the time he opened a print shop in London in 1784, he was already established as a graphic designer and drawing tutor. When he went to live in Sussex (1800-03), he was charged with high treason but acquitted, after which he returned to London. After a rather unsuccessful show of his artistic work in 1809, he went into obscurity and became a mystic. A radical supporter of the French Revolution, he was an outright critic of the social evils which he linked with the Industrial Revolution. His work as a poet and artist is usually understood in the context of his social, political, and religious beliefs. He was not understood by his peers but much has been

written on him by twentieth-century readers who appreciate the greatness he achieved in his many fields of interest.

Scan and Listen

The Lamb by William Blake - Read by Sir Ralph Richardson



The Tyger by William Blake - Read by Ian Richardson



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Songs of Innocence and Songs of Experience

Songs of Innocence was published in 1789 and Songs of Experience in 1794. Although these works are epoch-making in more ways than one, they hardly made an impact then. Jacob Bronowski says: "They were as formative for the culture of the 20th century in Europe and America as the Bible and The Pilgrim's Progress have been for an earlier age". Blake saw the shape of things to come; the problems of urban living, the power structures, the animosities among nations, and the bitter rivalries among industrial societies, Blake's prophetic insights made no sense to his contemporaries, but we are in a better position to understand the terrible truths conveyed in his poems. Blake has chosen simple models for these "songs". They are the hymns of Charles

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Wesley, the moral verse of Isaac Watts, and other Nonconformists. But there is one important difference, Blake reverses the roles of the poet and the child and makes the child teach the poet. Broadly, in Songs of Innocence, the child narrates the joys of life in nature; in Songs of Experience, the child is trapped in prisons of state and the Church.

Note on Songs of Innocence

The former are happy songs written to and about children, the latter depicts, to use Blake's own words, the "contrary state of the human soul". Songs of Innocence is a statement of the reaffirmation of the New Testament doctrine, "Lest ye become again as a little child ye cannot hope to enter the kingdom of heaven". This is underscored by Blake's use of pastoral Christian symbols (the Christ child, the lamb, the shepherd, etc.).

Note on Songs of Experience

Having experienced the hypocrisy and cruelty of the world personally, Blake was indignant in Songs of Experience. If Innocence is Heaven, Experience is Hell, Love and joy are suppressed by selfishness and by restrictions imposed by the priests (The Garden of Love). The children's laughter is silenced by adults; the children are exploited by an insensitive world (The Chimney-Sweeper), The Church and the State, two pillars of society, are indifferent. Sometimes they even connive, to cause suffering to children. Blake thought that these social evils were shameful. As a poet he could speak out with indignation and compassion. Russell Noyes says: "These songs reverberated the intensity of his feeling in brilliant denunciatory phrases, tight rhythms, and searing imagery. The best of them is rarely to be matched elsewhere in Blake, or (for that matter) in their kind in anyone else".

Note on *The Tyger*

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This is not only Blake's most famous poem but one of the great poems in the English language.

The first thing we notice in this poem is the unusual spelling of the word, "Tyger". Although Dr. Samuel Johnson mentioned it as an alternative form of the more common spelling, "Tiger", Blake's spelling conveys a unique feeling. In this context, it is important to remember that for Blake a poem is not a group of words presented linearly on a page, but a poem is a visual object. His engraving and painting are integral parts of his verbal art. Thus, a poem by Blake is meant to be seen and read. Only then is its full impact felt. So, the unconventional spelling reinforces our sense of wonder at the beauty, fierceness, and strength of the tiger.

Our astonishment is expressed through a series of fourteen questions in a span of twenty-four short lines. Eleven of these questions are fired rapidly in the first sixteen lines. In the first four stanzas, the poet attempts to augment the reader's sense of wonder progressively by asking a series of rhetorical questions on the extraordinary powers required for creating an animal

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like a tiger. The creator must possess the same qualities to be 'able to produce such a creature. The nature of the Tiger, as Lionel Trilling says, is defined by the nature of God. In the last two stanzas, there is a reversal of this procedure. God is defined by the nature of the Tiger. God who created a meek and mild creature like the lamb dared to create the ferocious Tiger. Earlier we saw that the lamb, the child, and Jesus are the same. That such a God created the tiger is not comprehensible to the stars who are the agents of divine law. As Blake himself suggests, it is the "contrary state of the soul". The Lamb and the Tiger represent two aspects of God and two states of man.

The sound effects in the poem are striking. The meter employed is trochaic tetrameter which is itself an unusual form. There is a good deal of alliteration and assonance. The diphthong (ai) in Tyger recurs throughout the poem. The poem may be explained in terms of the creation myth and the problem of good and evil in the world, what baffles man is that a kind God who created a mild lamb also created the ferocious Tiger. It is incredible; "Did he who made the Lamb make

thee?" The Book of Job in the Bible raises the same question.

The poem is a fine example of compression. The questions at the end of the stanza lack a verb:

And when thy heart began to beat

What dread hand? what dread feet?

This is the revised draft. Blake must have felt that the fragment is forceful enough and that it underscores the tone of exclamation. In one sense, The Tyger is a simple and enjoyable poem. It raises the common question: How do you account for the forces of good and evil in the universe. Blake's Tiger has a dual aspect, it is both beautiful and terrible as the repetitive phrase, "fearful symmetry", suggests. We should also remember that Blake turns from the Tiger to an examination of the nature of the creator.

Did he smile his work to see?

Did he who made the Lamb make thee?

There are allusions in the second stanza to daring attempts in mythology to challenge God: "On what

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wings dare he aspire?" is a reference to Icarus flying high towards the sun. The creator of the Tiger who had burning fire in his eyes must have had stronger wings than Icarus's wings joined by wax which melted due to the heat of the sun, In, the very next line there is another question. What the hand, dare seize the fire? This is a reference to Prometheus's stealing fire from heaven for mankind's benefit, these two acts of daring and courage are outdone in the creation of the tiger.

Suggested Reading

Kubla Khan – ST Coleridge

Ode to the West Wind – PB Shelley

Ode on A Grecian Urn – John Keats

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The Ransom of the Red Chief

- O Henry



William Sydney Porter lends the pen name "O. Henry" to surprise endings signed officially as Sydney Porter. His biography shows where he found inspiration for his characters. Their voices and his language were products of his era.

He was born 1862 Greensboro, North Carolina. When he was three years old, his mother died from tuberculosis. He left school at fifteen, worked five years in his uncle's drugstore, then for two years at a Texas sheep ranch.

In 1884 he went to Austin where he worked in a real estate office, a church choir, and spent four years as a draftsman in the General Land Office. His wife and firstborn died, but daughter Margaret survived him. After he failed to establish a small humorous weekly, he worked in poorly-run bank. When its accounts did not balance, he was blamed for it, and fired.

In Houston, he worked for a few years until — ordered to stand trial for embezzlement — he fled to New Orleans and thence, to Honduras.

Two years later, he returned on account of his wife's illness. Apprehended, Porter served a few months more than three years in a Penitentiary in Columbus, Ohio. During his incarceration, he composed ten short stories, including *A Blackjack Bargainer*, *The Enchanted Kiss*, and *The Duplicity of Hargraves*.

In 1899, McClure's published *Whistling Dick's Christmas Story* and *Georgia's Ruling*.

While in Pittsburgh, Pennsylvania, he sent manuscripts to New York editors. In the spring of 1902, *Ainslee's Magazine* offered him a regular income if he moved to New York.

In less than eight years, he became a bestselling author of collections of short stories. *Cabbages and Kings* came first, in 1904; followed by *The Four Million*; *The Trimmed Lamp* and *Heart of the West* in 1907; *The Voice of the City* in 1908; *Roads of Destiny* and *Options* in 1909, *Strictly Business* and *Whirligigs* in 1910.

Posthumously published collections include *The Gentle*

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Grafter about the swindler, Jeff Peters; *Rolling Stones* and *Waifs and Strays*; and in 1936, unsigned stories.

Others were rewarded financially more. *A Retrieved Reformation*, about the safe-cracker Jimmy Valentine, got \$250; six years later, \$500 for dramatic rights, which gave over \$100,000 royalties for playwright Paul Armstrong. Many stories have been made into films.



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The Ransom of the Red Chief Short Film



The Retrieved Reformation Short Film

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Summary of *The Ransom of the Red Chief*

The narrator, Sam, and his friend Bill are down in Summit, Alabama (a town as “flat as a flannel-cake”) when they are struck with the idea for the kidnapping. The two men need two thousand dollars to pull off a real estate scheme in Illinois. They’ve noted that “philoprogenitiveness” is “strong” in these semi-rural areas, so a “kidnapping project” ought to be a success—especially in a town small enough to lack interfering local journalists or a well-trained police force.

Sam and Bill select as their victim Johnny Dorset, the ten-year-old red-haired only child of “prominent citizen” Ebenezer Dorset. Ebenezer is a “collection-plate

passer and forecloser” who Sam and Bill believe can easily afford a \$2000 ransom. The men store supplies in a nearby cave two miles from town and, after sundown, they drive a rented buggy past Ebenezer’s house and try to entice Johnny, who is playing outside, into the buggy with an offer of candy. Johnny, who is “throwing rocks at a kitten,” responds to their offer by hitting Bill in the eye with a piece of brick.

Bill vows that the brick will cost Johnny’s father an extra \$500 ransom as they wrestle Johnny into the buggy. The boy struggles “like a welter-weight cinnamon bear” but they take him to the cave where Bill is left to watch him while Sam returns the buggy to town and then walks back to the remote cave.

When Sam returns, he discovers Bill tending to scratches and bruises, but the scene is calm with a fire and a pot of coffee. Johnny has “two buzzard tailfeathers stuck in his red hair.” Bill explains, “We’re playing Indian,” and that he is Red Chief’s captive, “to be scalped at daybreak.” Sam observes that the boy is happy camping in the cave and playing with Bill. Johnny also names Sam “Snake-eye, the Spy” and tells

him he will be broiled at the stake at sunrise. The three eat supper together.

Johnny says he’s never camped before, he had a possum, he hates school, and a rat ate his friend’s aunt’s hen’s eggs. He asks if there are real Indians in the woods and whether trees make the wind blow, and he states that his father has “lots of money.” He asks are the stars hot, says he doesn’t like girls, wonders if oxen make noise, why oranges are round, and if there are beds in the cave. He states a parrot can talk, but not a monkey or fish, and asks “how many does it take to make twelve?” From time to time, he goes to the mouth of the cave scanning the woods for imaginary paleface scouts, and making a war whoop that scares Bill. Sam asks if Johnny would like to go home, but Johnny pleads not to be taken back. Sam assures him they will stay in the cave a while, and Johnny says, “That’ll be fine. I never had such fun in all my life.”

Sam and Bill go to sleep with Johnny between them, not afraid he will run away. He continues to play his fantasy for hours, jumping up at sounds outside the cave, and trying to rouse his new friends with shouts of

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“Hist! pard.” Sam has a bad dream where he is kidnapped by a pirate with red hair and, at daybreak, awakes to Bill’s “indecent, terrifying, humiliating screams” as Johnny, playing Red Chief, acts as though he is trying to scalp Bill.

Sam takes the knife from Johnny and makes him lay down, but Bill is shaken and doesn’t sleep. Sam dozes for a while but wakes early, remembering Johnny’s fantasy threat to burn him at the stake. Bill asks why he’s up so early and Sam claims he has a pain in his shoulder, but Bill accuses him of being afraid of the boy, and asks whether anyone would pay money to get “a little imp like that” back. Sam reassures him that parents dote on rowdy kids and tells him to cook breakfast for Johnny while he goes up to the mountain top to observe any activity around them.

Sam goes up on the peak of a nearby mountain and sees nothing to indicate that anyone is concerned about a missing child. He expected to see the local population armed with pitchforks, searching for kidnappers, but instead all is peaceful across the landscape. He likens his capture of Johnny to wolves

taking a lamb, but doubt creeps into his mind as he thinks, “Heaven help the wolves!” Sam returns to the camp for breakfast only to find that Johnny is once again threatening Bill with bodily harm, this time with a rock half the size of a coconut. Bill complains that the boy burned him with a red-hot potato and asks sheepishly if Sam has a gun.

After breakfast, Johnny takes a leather slingshot and goes out of the cave. Bill is worried, wondering what he’s up to and if he’s trying to run away. Sam tells Bill not to worry, and says that he’s headed to town that night to deliver the ransom message, having seen little evidence in the surrounding area of any concern for the lost boy. Suddenly, with a war-whoop, Johnny attacks Bill with a large black rock, hurled with a sling-like David slaying Goliath. The impact sends Bill sprawling into the campfire, and Sam tends to his friend for half an hour, pouring cold water on his head.

Bill mentions that his favourite Bible character is King Herod, the King who doubts Jesus and turns him over to the Romans for execution. Sam grabs Johnny and shakes him, reprimands him, and then threatens to

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take the boy home if he doesn't behave. Sam makes Johnny apologize and tasks Bill with being Johnny's playmate while he goes into a neighbouring town, Poplar Cove, to see if anyone has heard of a missing child yet.

After Bill and Johnny shake hands, Sam tells Bill they should send the "peremptory" ransom note to Ebenezer. Bill reminds Sam that he's stood by him through many hardships and difficult situations, but he urges him to be quick since he's concerned about his own safety around Johnny, whom he calls "that two-legged skyrocket of a kid" and "that forty-pound chunk of freckled wildcat." Sam agrees to return quickly, and he and Bill work on the ransom letter while Johnny plays Indian Chief, strutting around like he's the one guarding captives. In tears, Bill convinces Sam to reduce the ransom demand to \$1500 from \$2000 to increase the likelihood that they will be able to return the troublesome child soon.

Sam writes the letter to Ebenezer asking for \$1500 in large bills in exchange for his son. The answer is to be sent by a solitary messenger to a remote location outside

town, and Sam details the exact time and location (at the bottom of a fence-post bordering a wheat field opposite the third of three trees past Owl Creek on the road to Poplar Cove). The threat is "you will never see your boy again" and he states the terms are final and, when agreed to, Johnny will be returned within 3 hours. With the letter in his pocket, Sam encounters Johnny, who asks if he and Bill can play the Black Scout game while he's gone, since he's tired of being an Indian chief. Sam assures him, "Of course... Mr. Bill will play with you."

Sam tells Johnny that Bill will play his new game, warning Bill that he should keep the child occupied until he returns from delivering the ransom note. As Sam leaves the two, Bill gets down on all fours to play the part of Black Scout's horse, with Johnny on his back. Sam admonishes Bill to keep the boy interested, saying "Loosen up." Bill discovers it's 90 miles to the stockade in Johnny's fantasy, as Johnny digs his heels into Bill's side. Bill asks Sam to hurry back and wishes aloud they had made the ransom only \$1000.

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Sam walks to the neighbouring town of Poplar Cove and overhears someone saying all Summit is upset because Johnny has gone missing. Satisfied that the plan is finally working, Sam posts his ransom note to Ebenezer in Summit and leaves to return to the cave and await a response. When Sam returns to the cave, he can't find Bill or Johnny anywhere, so he waits. After half an hour, Bill returns to camp, wiping his face with a red handkerchief, while Johnny creeps along like a scout behind him.

Bill apologizes to Sam for having sent Johnny home, but declares he could no longer endure the hardship of caring for him as a captive. Bill details how he was ridden as a horse in the game of Black Scout, and Johnny attempted to feed him sand as if it were oats. He compares his experience with “martyrs in old times” and says he was subjected to “supernatural tortures.” He also details the childish questions Johnny asks, such as “why there was nothin’ in holes” as proof that caring for him was beyond what any person could endure. Bill concludes by telling Sam he took Johnny down the mountain and sent him home, and with him

their hopes of a ransom. It was either that or “Bill Driscoll to the madhouse.”

Sam asks Bill to turn around and see that Johnny has been following behind him all along. Bill sees him and sits down in resignation, plucking at grass and sticks in a hopeless state. Sam encourages him with the thought that the kidnapping scheme might soon come to a conclusion, and Bill recovers enough to promise Johnny yet another fantasy game with him, playing a Russian in a Japanese war.

Sam climbs the tree above the arranged drop off location to await Ebenezer’s answer. At the appointed time, a young messenger rides up on a bicycle, slips a folder paper into the box at the foot of the fencepost, and rides back toward Summit. Sam waits an hour to avoid “being caught by counterplots” and then, believing no one is watching, comes down to get the note and returns to the cave. Once there, he observes the note was written in a “crabbed hand,” and he reads it to Bill by the light of a lantern.

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Ebenezer's letter declares that Sam's ransom demand is too high, and he makes a counter-proposition: they are to return the boy and pay Ebenezer \$250 to take Johnny back. Ebenezer recommends that they come at night, since he can't be responsible for the actions of his neighbours (who believe Johnny is lost) should Sam and Bill be seen during the day bringing back his troublesome boy.

Sam is shocked at the audacity of Ebenezer's response, but Bill is relieved to think their ordeal may finally be at an end. Bill argues that \$250 is a low price for freedom from Johnny, and he urges Sam to agree to the counter offer. Sam agrees Johnny is too much trouble and that they should cut their losses. They lie to Johnny that his father bought him a silver-mounted rifle and moccasins, and they say that they will take him bear-hunting if he will agree to go home.

At midnight, Sam and Bill bring Johnny to Ebenezer's house in Summit and pay him \$250. Johnny, upset when realizing his friends are leaving, clings to Bill's leg and has to be peeled away by his father. Old Dorset restrains his son, saying, "I'm not as strong as I

used to be... but I think I can promise you ten minutes." Bill outruns Sam, as the two of them leg it out of town, headed perhaps to the Canadian border.

The Ransom of the Red Chief Analysis

Characters:

SAM

Sam is one of the main characters of the story. He is also the narrator of the story.

Sam along with his friend Bill is the protagonist of the story. They both have jointly six hundred dollars but they need two thousand more to carry out a project. They plan to kidnap a child from the town of Summit but the plan badly fails.

BILL DRISCOLL

Bill is another main character or protagonist in the story. It is Bill who gives the idea of kidnapping a child. He is also a victim of Johnny's mischievousness. Johnny beats him and forces him to play with him. In

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the end, Bill repents his idea of kidnapping and wants to take Johnny back home without even taking the ransom. He rather accepts to pay an extra amount to Johnny's father for taking his annoying boy back.

JOHNNY DORSET

The ten years old boy with red hair named Johnny Dorset is the only son of Ebenezer Dorset. He is the antagonist in the story. The story says that Johnny is red-haired where red hair is a sign of wild character. His father is a well-known wealthy man in the town of Summit. Johnny gets kidnapped for a ransom of two thousand dollars but he is so naughty that he spoils the kidnappers' plan. He calls himself 'Red Chief', an ideal character in a game. He drives the kidnappers crazy.

EBENEZER DORSET

A Wealthy man who belongs to the town of Summit. He is the father of Johnny Dorset. His son is kidnapped and the kidnappers demand for ransom in return to Johnny's release. Ebenezer Dorset, unlike fathers, in reality, does not search for his son. He is not even worried that his son has been kidnapped. He

rather asks the kidnappers to pay him money to take his son back. It shows that he is well aware of the wild and uncontrollable nature of his son.

Themes:

DAYDREAMING VS REALITY

This theme is highlighted in the short story 'The Ransom of Red Chief' that if we daydream about something. We want it to turn out the way we wish but the reality can be different as the kidnappers who dream of gaining two thousand dollars by kidnapping a child but the reality turns out to be different and they give away money instead of gaining.

NOTHING IS A SURE THING

This story develops a twisted plot and an unexpected ending. The kidnappers are sure of their plan and they think that it will work out perfectly but at the end, the opposite thing happens.

EXPECT THE UNEXPECTED

This story highlights the theme that Expectations are not always fulfilled. The kidnappers expect to gain

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money by kidnapping a child but the plan gets spoiled and they are compelled to give away some of their money.

CRIME DOES NOT PAY

The short story 'The Ransom of Red Chief' emphasizes the idea that unlawful means of gaining money is a bad thing and it may not pay us as expected. The two men decide to get money by kidnapping a child which is a crime. By doing so they lose their own money which means crime can cost you even more.

Significance of the Title:

The title "The Ransom of Red Chief" is significant in providing a clue to the reader about the plot. The title is in fact an irony. In the beginning of the story, the reader thinks that the kidnappers' plan would be successful and they would get the ransom of the little boy in return for his release. But the reader gets astonished when the story closes. The ransom that the kidnappers want to release Johnny, they are compelled to pay it to his father, to get rid of the mischievous boy.

Literary Devices:

IRONY

Irony is a literary device in which what is expected is different from what actually happens.

The story 'The Ransom of Red Chief' is full of irony. The examples of irony in the story are as follows:

DRAMATIC IRONY

Dramatic Irony is when the audience or readers know something but the character of the story does not know it.

Dramatic Irony in 'The Ransom of Red Chief' is when Bill takes Johnny back home and he does not know that Johnny is following him back to the cave while the reader knows it.

VERBAL IRONY

This is the type of irony in which the writer uses such words that say something different from what they actually mean.

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‘Summit’, the name of the town is an example of verbal irony in this story. Summit actually means peak or the highest point in a mountain but in the story, it is used for a flat town.

SITUATIONAL IRONY

This type of irony is when the opposite of what is expected, happens.

Situational irony in the story is when Sam and Bill expect to get money as a ransom of the little boy but the opposite of it occurs.

METAPHOR

A metaphor is when a word or phrase is applied to an object or action to which it is not literally applicable. It is the indirect comparison between two things.

There are many examples of metaphors in ‘The Ransom of Red Chief’. One of the examples is when Johnny tried to remove Bill’s scalp with a knife, Bill was extremely terrified as the narrator says “Bill’s spirit was broken.”

SIMILE

Simile is the direct comparison of two things. ‘The Ransom of Red Chief’ has many examples of simile. One example of simile is when Johnny plays with Bill. The narrator says that “Bill gets down on all his fours and a look comes in his eye like a rabbit’s when you catch it in a trap.”

Suggested Reading

A Retrieved Reformation

The A Service of Love

Gift of Magi Chief Seattle’s Speech

Memoirs of a Yellow Dog

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